

The Quick Game: Slant-Flat, Stick, Snag, Quick Screens, and Beating Press

Throws that leave the quarterback's hand in about two seconds: what they are, how he picks one before the snap, and why every offense needs them

Third-and-6, midway through the second quarter. Before the snap the slot defender creeps toward the line, and both linebackers walk up into the gaps beside the center. Six defenders are now standing within a yard or two of the ball, and the broadcast's analyst says the word you have heard a thousand times: *blitz*. The ball is snapped. The quarterback takes one big step back from the shotgun, plants, and throws. The outside receiver, who had run three steps upfield and cut sharply inside, catches it eight yards downfield and falls forward for a first down. The play took about two seconds. Nobody touched the quarterback, and the replay doesn't even bother to show the rush. How did the quarterback know where to throw before the blitz got to him? Why was the receiver open at all, with so many defenders so close? And why do so many drives, even for the best quarterbacks in the league, live on throws that travel five yards? This chapter is about the family of plays that answers all three questions: the **quick game**.

You'll be able to...

- Say what the quick game is for (beating pressure, keeping the offense on schedule, stretching the run game sideways) and what an offense gives up by living on it.
- Draw slant-flat, stick, snag, spacing, the speed out, double slants and hitch-seam, and name the one defender each concept puts in a bind.
- Read a defender's leverage before the snap and pick the side and the route the way a quarterback does.
- Follow a receiver's fight against press coverage, step by step: release, stem, stack, break, catch point, and the double move that punishes a defender for guessing.
- Spot now and bubble screens and the soft or crowded alignments that invite them.
- Time a quick throw from your couch and recognize it as the offense's standard answer to press coverage and the blitz.

You'll need

- **Routes, drops and stretches** from Passing Fundamentals: the route tree (slant, hitch, flat, out, seam, go), the quarterback's drop, and the two ways to put one defender in a bind, the high-low (vertical) stretch and the horizontal stretch.
- **Protection and hot throws** from Pass Protection: five-, six- and seven-man protections, the free rusher, hot routes and sight adjustments, and *time to throw*.
- **A first look at defense** from A First Look at Defense: man and zone, one-high and two-high, the box, and what makes a rush a blitz.
- **Formation words** from Spread and Modern Formations: 2x2 and trips, and counting receivers from the sideline in as #1, #2, #3.

What the quick game is

The **quick game** is the set of pass plays built to get the ball out in roughly **2.5 seconds or less**. Three things make a pass play "quick," and they go together:

1. **A short drop.** From under center, the quarterback takes three steps back (a three-step drop); from the shotgun, already five yards deep, he takes one step or three short ones. There's no time to drift, reset or scan.
2. **Short routes.** Most receivers break at five or six yards or less: slants, hitches, flats, short outs. One receiver often runs deep, but mainly to drag a defender out of the way.
3. **A throw timed to the break.** The ball leaves as the quarterback's back foot lands, aimed at the spot where the receiver *will be* when he makes his cut. If the throw is late, the play is usually dead.

Nothing in the rulebook defines it, and teams draw the line in different places, but analysts usually treat throws out in under 2.5 seconds as "quick." In 2025 about half of all NFL pass attempts came out that fast; the median attempt left the quarterback's hand

at 2.5 seconds.¹ That's the first thing to understand about the quick game: it is not a gadget or a change-up. It is a large share of everything an NFL offense throws.

Why it exists: three jobs

The quick game survives in every playbook, from the old 49ers to the modern Chiefs, because it does three jobs no other part of the offense does as cheaply.

Job 1: beat the pass rush with the clock. A pass rush is a race. Four rushers against five blockers usually need well over two and a half seconds to get home, if they get there at all; a blitz nobody blocks can arrive in about two. The quarterback can win that race in two ways: block long enough for the deep routes to develop, or throw before the rush matters. The quick game is the second way. It can't be sacked if the ball is already gone, and it doesn't need the offensive line to win, only to hold for a heartbeat.

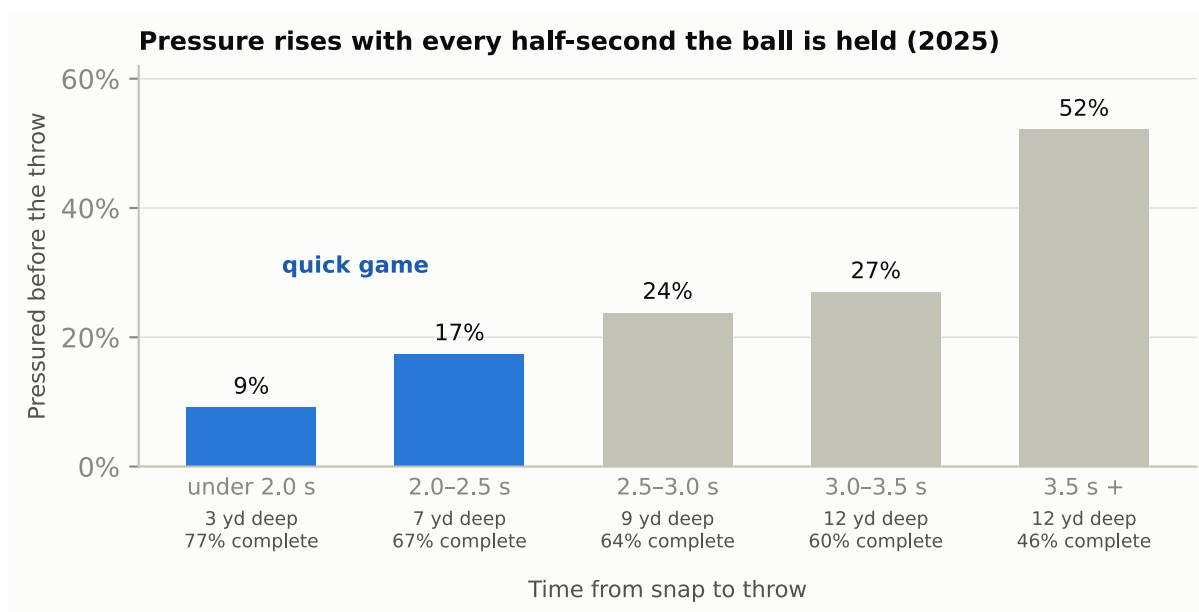


Figure 1: The longer the ball stays in the quarterback's hand, the more often the rush gets to him, and the farther the ball goes when it is thrown. Every bar is a group of 2025 regular-season pass attempts sorted by time from snap to throw; the bar is the share on which the quarterback was pressured (hit, hurried or chased) before he threw. The two blue bars, throws out in under 2.5 seconds, are the quick game's territory. Below each bar: the average depth of the throw past the line of scrimmage and the completion rate. Sacks are not throws, so they are left out; counting them would make the right-hand bars worse still.

The chart shows the bargain in one picture. Throws out in under two seconds were pressured about one time in eleven; throws held three and a half seconds or more, about half the time. But look underneath the bars: the quick throws also went only three to seven yards past the line of scrimmage on average, against eleven or twelve for the slow ones. Fast and short come as a package.

Job 2: keep the offense on schedule. A first down takes ten yards in three plays, and the plays that kill drives are the ones that lose yards or gain none: sacks, incompletions, and the third-and-long that follows them. Coaches call staying ahead of the chains being on schedule: roughly, gaining four or more on first down and half the remaining distance on second. Quick throws are completed far more often (in 2025, about 72% of attempts out in under 2.5 seconds were caught, against 57% of the rest) and almost never end in a sack, so they keep the offense in second-and-5 instead of second-and-10.² By the success-rate yardstick (did the play gain enough to stay on track?), quick throws succeeded on about 51% of attempts, slower throws on about 45%.

Job 3: stretch the run game sideways. Bill Walsh, who built the most influential short passing offense in NFL history, started from a team that couldn't run the ball well enough to control a game, so he used short, high-percentage throws to do the running game's job; his throws have often been described as extended handoffs.³ A five-yard pass to a receiver near the sideline gets the

¹Course calculation from nflverse participation data (time_to_throw, FTN-sourced), 2025 regular season: 17,394 pass attempts with a recorded time (sacks, spikes and scrambles excluded). Median 2.5 seconds; 48% of attempts left the quarterback's hand in under 2.5 seconds and 52% in 2.5 seconds or less. The 2.5-second line is an analysts' convention, not a rule; PFF, for one, splits time to throw there (PFF, "Signature Stat Snapshot: Time To Throw": <https://www.pff.com/news/signature-stat-snapshot-time-to-throw>).

²Course calculation, same data: attempts out in under 2.5 seconds were completed 72.2% of the time (success rate 51.5%), slower attempts 57.1% (success rate 44.9%). Success means positive EPA, the definition in Expected Points, EPA and Success Rate.

³Walsh to Tom FitzGerald of the *San Francisco Chronicle*: "We couldn't control the football with the run; [opposing] teams were just too strong. So it had to be the forward pass, and obviously it had to be a high-percentage, short, controlled passing game." The same profile describes his offense as "passes so

ball to a fast player in space, away from the big defenders in the middle, and lets him run. In 2025 about 59% of the receiving yards on quick completions came *after* the catch, against about 38% on slower ones.⁴ That is the defining fact of the quick game: the throw is short and the run after it does most of the work. It also means that a defense that wants to stop the quick game has to tackle in space, on the edges of the field, where it has the fewest defenders.

! Why it exists, and what it costs

The quick game trades **depth for certainty**. The offense gives up the chance of a big gain through the air for a high chance of a small gain, a near-zero chance of a sack, and a receiver running with the ball before the defense is set.

The bill comes in three parts. First, **the defense can squeeze it**. If an offense never threatens deep, defenders creep closer and the short windows shrink; quick game works best when the defense still has to respect the deep ball. Second, **it needs yards after the catch**: a five-yard throw that is tackled at five yards on third-and-7 is a punt. Third, **it gets harder as the field shrinks**: near the goal line there is less room to run after the catch. The rest of this chapter is about how good offenses keep the bargain on their side.

A short history: the offense built around a quarterback without a big arm

The modern quick game has many fathers, but the most important is **Bill Walsh**, and his starting point was a problem, not a philosophy. In 1970 Walsh was an assistant coach with the Cincinnati Bengals, a three-year-old expansion team run by Paul Brown. The Bengals' brilliant young starter, Greg Cook, had wrecked his throwing shoulder as a rookie in 1969, and the job went to **Virgil Carter**, a smart, mobile quarterback who could not throw the ball deep with any authority. Walsh's answer was to build the passing game around what Carter *could* do: short, timed throws to receivers spread across the field, with the backs and tight ends as targets, so the ball came out on rhythm and the receivers did the running. In 1971 Carter led the NFL in completion percentage.⁵ Carter, who had studied statistics in college and took an MBA during his playing career, also co-wrote one of the first academic papers to estimate the expected points value of field position: the same idea this book uses as its scorecard.⁶

Walsh took the approach to San Diego, to Stanford, and in 1979 to the San Francisco 49ers, where with Joe Montana it became the backbone of three Super Bowl champions (after the 1981, 1984 and 1988 seasons).⁷ The slant to Jerry Rice, thrown on rhythm before the cornerback could react and turned into a long touchdown by Rice's speed, was its signature: Rice caught a record 22 touchdown passes in just 12 games in 1987.⁸ The broad family of offenses descended from Walsh's ideas came to be called the West Coast offense, a label with a tangled history that Offensive Systems and Languages untangles. What matters here is the idea Walsh proved: a passing game built on short, accurate, on-time throws could control a game the way a power running game did.

A rule change helped. In 1978 the NFL barred defenders from contacting receivers more than five yards past the line of scrimmage; until then a defensive back could keep bumping a receiver well down the field.⁹ Receivers who could no longer be mugged at eight and ten yards made short timing routes far more reliable, and passing numbers rose across the league. Walsh arrived in San Francisco a year later.

short they were effectively extended handoffs." Both in "Walsh, Bill," *Encyclopedia.com*: <https://www.encyclopedia.com/people/sports-and-games/sports-biographies/bill-walsh>

⁴Course calculation, same data: on 2025 completions thrown in under 2.5 seconds, 58.7% of receiving yards came after the catch; on slower completions, 38.5%. Screens are included, which pushes the quick figure up: about 23% of throws out in under 2 seconds were screens (FTN [is_screen_pass](#)).

⁵Bill Walsh with Brian Billick and James A. Peterson, *Finding the Winning Edge* (Sports Publishing, 1997), on building the Bengals' short passing game around Virgil Carter. "West Coast offense," *Wikipedia*: Walsh "was tasked with devising an offensive plan suited to Bengal quarterback Virgil Carter, who had an accurate but relatively weak arm," and Carter "led the league in passing percentage in 1971": https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/West_Coast_offense. Carter completed 138 of 222 (62.2%), the NFL's best that season: Pro Football Reference, 1971 NFL leaders, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/years/1971/leaders.htm>. Greg Cook tore the rotator cuff in his throwing shoulder in the third game of 1969, played through the season, then needed surgeries that kept him out of the next three seasons: "Greg Cook," *Wikipedia*, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Greg_Cook. The Bengals began play in 1968.

⁶Virgil Carter and Robert E. Machol, "Operations Research on Football," *Operations Research* 19, no. 2 (1971): 541–544, which estimated the expected-point value of first-and-10 at each part of the field from 8,373 plays in the first 56 games of the 1969 NFL season: <https://ideas.repec.org/a/inm/oropre/v19y1971i2p541-544.html>. On Carter's statistics major at BYU and his MBA at Northwestern, taken while he played for the Bears: ESPN, "Ex-Bengals QB Virgil Carter's legacy of EPA, other analytics" (2024): https://www.espn.com.au/nfl/story/_/id/40276150/nfl-epa-analytics-virgil-carter-cincinnati-bengals

⁷Pro Football Hall of Fame, "Bill Walsh" (Class of 1993): head coach of the 49ers 1979–1988, winners of Super Bowls XVI, XIX and XXIII: <https://www.profootballhof.com/players/bill-walsh/>

⁸Pro Football Hall of Fame, "Jerry Rice" (Class of 2010), including his 22 touchdown catches in the strike-shortened 12-game 1987 season, then an NFL record (Randy Moss caught 23 in 2007): <https://www.profootballhof.com/players/jerry-rice/>

⁹Pro Football Hall of Fame, NFL history, 1978: "Rules changes permitted a defender to maintain contact with a receiver within five yards of the line of scrimmage, but restricted contact beyond that point": <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1960-1979/1978>; and 1977: "Defenders were permitted to make contact with eligible receivers only once": <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1960-1979/1977>. The 1978 change is often called the "Mel Blount rule" (Steelers Depot, "Mel Blount explains play that created Mel Blount rule," 2024: <https://steelersdepot.com/2024/02/mel-blount-explains-play-that-created-mel-blount-rule/>). The era is the subject of *The 1978 Liberation*.

Rhythm: the drop and the throw are one motion

Watch a quick throw from the end-zone camera and you'll notice that the quarterback never seems to *decide* anything. He catches the snap, takes his steps, and the ball is gone on the last one. That is a **rhythm throw**: a pass thrown on the last step of the drop, with no hitch or hesitation, so the ball arrives just as the receiver breaks.

The rhythm is the whole point. The quarterback's drop and the receiver's route are designed together, step for step: a three-step drop under center, or a one- or three-step drop from the shotgun, is timed to a receiver who breaks at about five or six yards (Passing Fundamentals lays out the matched pairs). When the quarterback's back foot hits, the receiver is making his cut, and the ball leaves. From the shotgun, that is usually about a second to a second and a half after the snap. If the quarterback has to hitch (take an extra reset step) or look somewhere else, the timing is gone and a different, slower play has begun.

That has a consequence that shapes the whole quick game: **the quarterback has almost no time to read the defense after the snap**. He gets one look, at one defender, and has to know in advance what that defender's answer means. Most of the "reading" therefore happens *before* the snap. To see how, we need one more piece of vocabulary.

Leverage: the pre-snap read

Look at any cornerback before the snap and ask a simple question: is he lined up *inside* the receiver, *outside* him, or straight in front of him? That position is his **leverage**, and it is the most important thing a quarterback looks at before a quick throw.

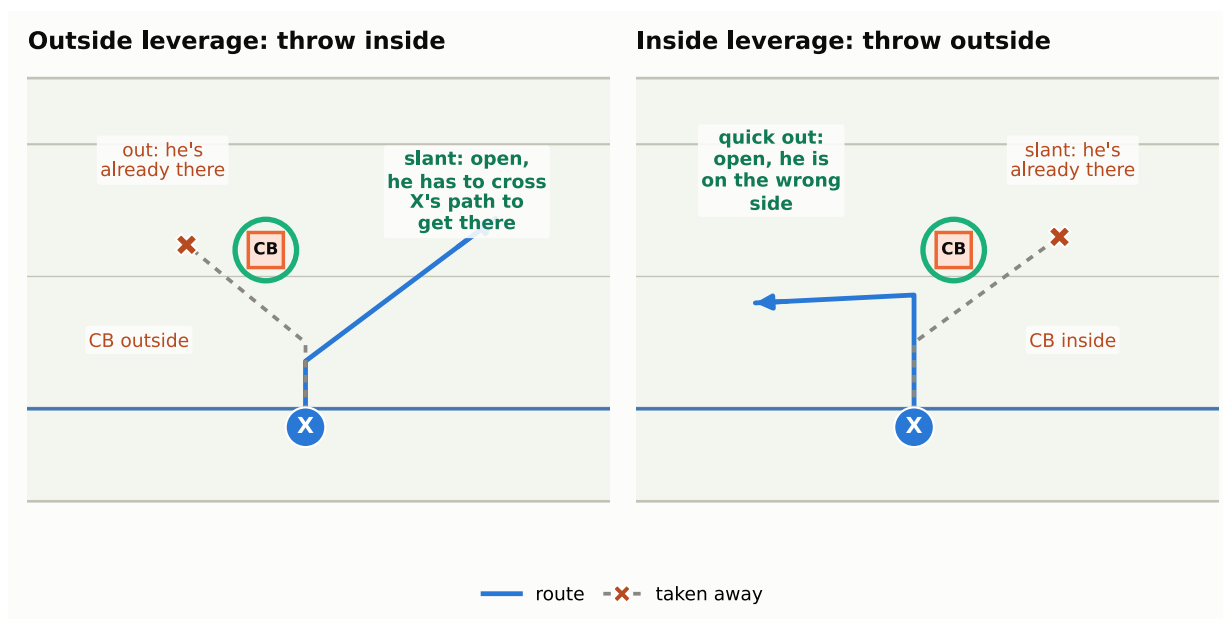


Figure 2: Leverage, from the quarterback's side of the ball. Left: the cornerback lines up a yard and a half outside the receiver, protecting the sideline (outside leverage). Routes toward the sideline run into him; a route that breaks inside, like the slant, starts on the side he isn't on. Right: the cornerback lines up inside the receiver (inside leverage), protecting the middle; now the quick out is the route that starts on the open side. Throw away from leverage.

Why would a defender give anything away on purpose? Because he can't take everything away, so he takes away what his teammates can't help him with. A defender usually lines up on the side **where he has no help**, and funnels the receiver toward the side where he does. A cornerback with a safety deep in the middle and linebackers underneath often plays outside leverage: his teammates can help on routes inside, the sideline can't. A corner whose help is outside (a defender sitting in the flat in front of him, say) plays inside leverage. So leverage is not just one man's position. It is a clue to the whole coverage behind him.

The quarterback's rule is short: **throw away from leverage**. A route that breaks toward the side the defender *isn't* on gains a step at the break, because the defender has to cross the receiver's path, or run around him, to get there. That's the core of the **pre-snap read**: a look at the defense's alignment before the snap (leverage, the cushion, meaning how far off the receiver the defender stands, the safeties, the box) that tells the quarterback which side, or which receiver, a play should go to. Many quick-game calls are drawn with a concept on *each* side of the formation for exactly this reason: the quarterback picks the side whose leverage he likes before the ball is snapped, then reads one defender on that side after it.

Three numbers belong in every pre-snap read of a single receiver:

- **Inside, outside or head-up?** Head-up (straight in front) is a defender who has decided to guess, and it is common in press coverage. We'll come back to it.
- **How deep?** A defender seven or eight yards off can't stop a short throw from being caught; he can only tackle the catch. One pressed up at the line can disrupt the route itself.
- **Where is his help?** A deep safety over the top lets a cornerback sit on short routes. No safety at all means the cornerback has to protect against the deep ball first.

Common misconception

"The quarterback reads the coverage after the snap." For deep dropback passes, mostly yes. For the quick game, the important decision is made before the snap and the post-snap read is a single glance at a single defender. When you see a quarterback throw the instant his foot lands, he isn't guessing; he made the decision ten seconds earlier, from the alignment, and the snap merely confirmed it.

Slant-flat: the high-low

Now the concepts. A pass concept is a set of routes designed to work together, usually to put one defender in a position where he can't be right. Every quick concept in this chapter is built on one of the two stretches from Passing Fundamentals: a high-low (one receiver above a defender, one below him) or a horizontal stretch (one inside him, one outside him). The defender being stretched is the one the quarterback watches.

The simplest quick concept in football is **slant-flat**. The outside receiver runs a slant: three hard steps upfield, then a sharp break inside at about 45 degrees. The inside receiver runs to the flat, the area near the sideline just past the line of scrimmage. Between them stands one defender, usually the slot defender or an outside linebacker, whose job in most zone coverages is to guard the short area outside: the *flat defender* (or, in Cover 3 language, the curl-flat defender). He is the read.

The quarterback's thought process is one sentence long: **"If the flat defender widens, throw the slant; if he sits, throw the flat."** He doesn't have to diagnose the coverage, find the safeties or work through five receivers. He has to watch one man take one step. That's why slant-flat is often the first pass concept a young quarterback learns, and why it survives at every level of the sport.

Notice what each route is doing to the defender. The flat route is a *low* threat: it pulls him toward the sideline and forward. The slant is a *high* threat: it attacks the space behind him and inside him. He can't be in both places, and he has to commit in about half a second. If he widens, he has opened the door the slant runs through. If he stays put (or "sinks" into the slant's path), the inside receiver catches the ball in the flat with no one within five yards, which on most downs is a fine result: a "long handoff" to the edge.

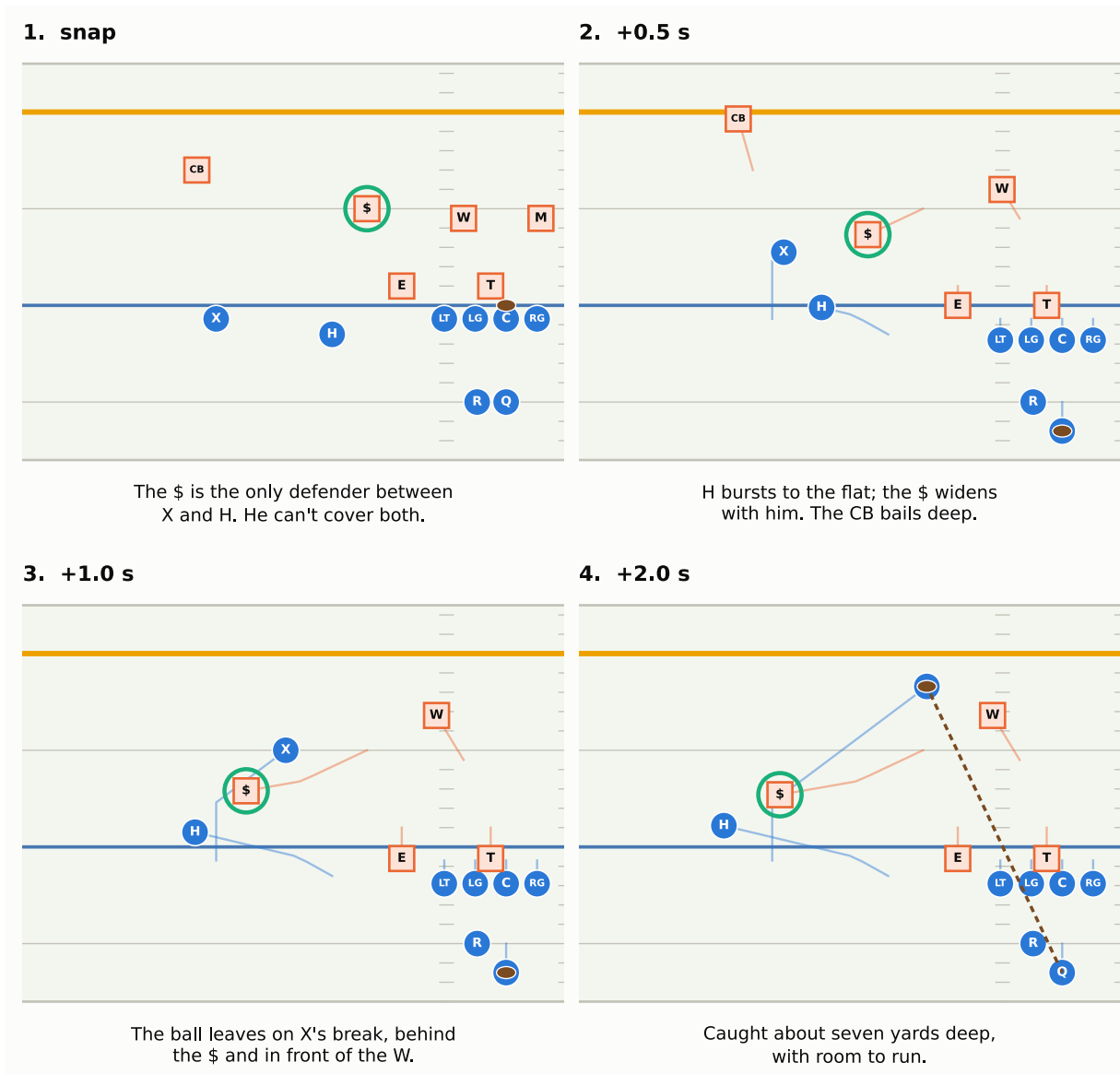


Figure 3: Slant-flat against a Cover 3 look, the offense's left side (simulated, BDB-format tracking). The ringed defender, the nickel back (\$), is the quarterback's only read. He stands between two receivers going in two directions: X's slant above and inside him, H's flat below and outside him. Here he widens with H, so the ball goes to X on the slant, into the space between the \$ and the Will linebacker (W). Had he stayed inside, the throw would have gone to H in the flat. The ball is out about one second after the snap; faint lines are where each player has been, brown dashes the ball in flight.

What does slant-flat give up? Depth. The best case is a slant caught at seven or eight yards with room to run; the usual case is a flat route for four or five. It also needs the cornerback to cooperate: against a corner who sits low in the flat (as in Cover 2, where corners squat short), the flat is covered by a second man and the slant must fit into a tighter window. That's where the other concepts come in.

Stick: the in-out

Stick is one of the most-called quick concepts in the NFL, and you met it in *What a Play Really Is* as that chapter's one example play. Here is why it is so popular. Slant-flat stretches the flat defender vertically; stick stretches him *horizontally*, inside and outside, at a depth that usually reaches the line to gain on second or third and medium.

Three receivers on one side. The outside man (#1) runs off, deep: a go route or a fade that carries the cornerback away. The next man (#2, usually a tight end or a slot) runs to about six yards and **sticks**: he settles in the open space and turns to face the quarterback, or, against man coverage, breaks away from his defender. The third man (#3, often the running back) runs to the flat. The stick sits inside the flat defender; the flat route goes outside him.

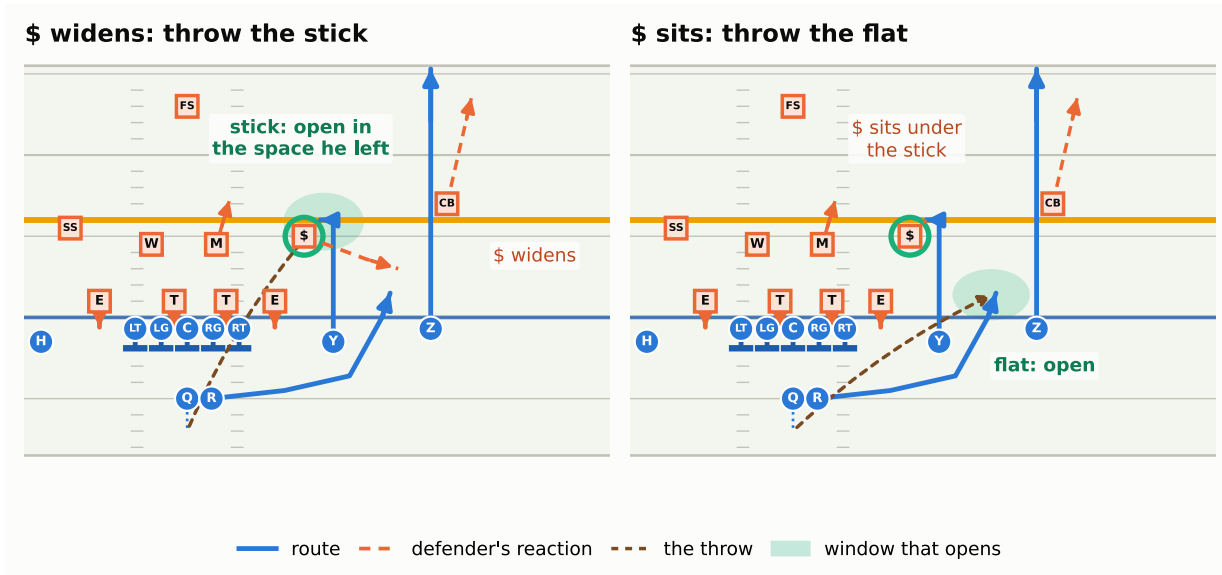


Figure 4: Stick from 2x2, run to the offense's right against a Cover 3 look: Z clears out deep, Y (a tight end split into the slot) runs six yards and settles, and the running back runs to the flat. The ringed nickel back (\$) is the read, and the two panels are his two choices. Left: he widens toward the back in the flat, so the stick is open in the space he left. Right: he sits under the stick, so the back is alone in the flat. The Mike linebacker (M) drops to the middle and is too far inside to help on the stick in time; the cornerback goes deep with Z.

The stick route itself is the clever part. It isn't a hitch with a fixed landmark; it's a rule. Against zone, the receiver finds the soft spot between the flat defender and the next defender inside (the Mike linebacker here) and sits in it, facing the quarterback, so the ball can be thrown the moment he settles. Against man coverage, there is no soft spot to find, because a defender is following him, so he breaks away from that defender's leverage, in or out. That's an option route in miniature, and it is why the quarterback and the stick runner rehearse it endlessly: both of them have to see the same thing.

Stick is everywhere because it does three things at once. It puts the ball at or near the line to gain on the downs where five or six yards matter most. It works against most zone coverages, because nearly all of them have *one* defender responsible for both the area inside and the area outside at that depth. And the clear-out by #1 keeps a deep threat on the field, so the cornerback can't come up and sit on everything short.

Snag: the triangle

Slant-flat stretches one defender up and down; stick stretches him side to side. **Snag** does both at once by putting three receivers in a triangle, so two defenders are stuck guarding three spots. (Some teams call it *spot*.)

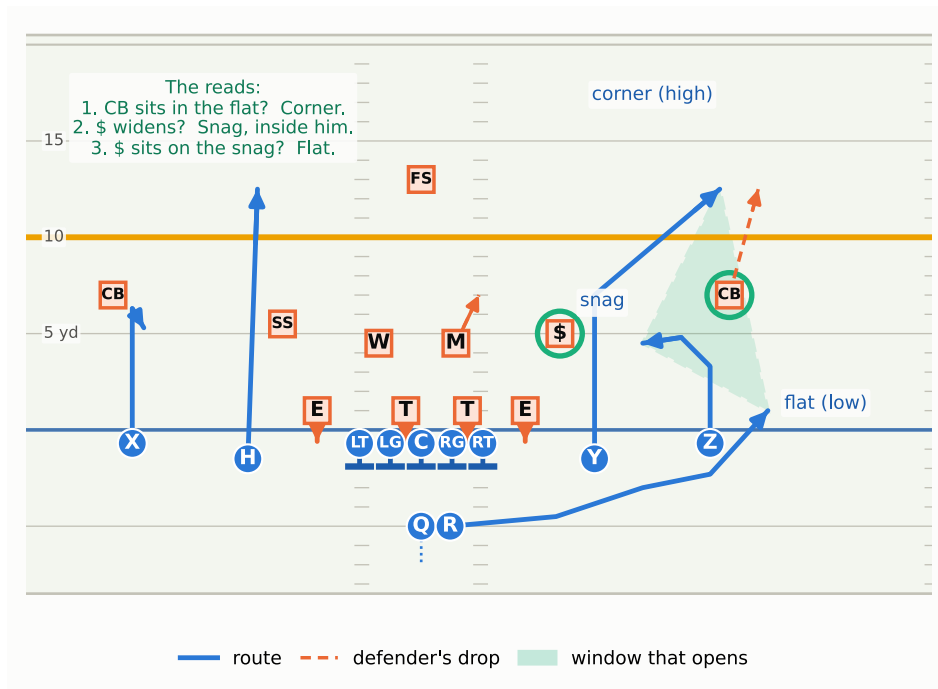


Figure 5: Snag to the offense's right against a Cover 3 look. Z, the outside receiver, pushes upfield five yards and settles just inside where he started (the snag). Y, from the slot, runs a corner route over the top, toward the back pylon. The running back runs to the flat. Together they make a triangle (shaded): a high-low on the cornerback (corner route over, flat under) and an in-out on the flat defender (snag inside, flat outside). The quarterback's reads are in the box.

Against Cover 3, the cornerback has a deep third and bails, so the corner route is usually covered and the quarterback's eyes go to the flat defender, exactly as in stick. Against Cover 2, the cornerback sits in the flat with a safety deep behind him, and the corner route attacks the hole between them: the corner has to choose between the flat (low) and the corner route (high). Either way, somebody is left with two receivers to guard. The quarterback reads the triangle from the top or the bottom depending on the coverage he identified before the snap, which is the pre-snap read doing its job again.

A word about the triangle. Coaches love it because it combines both kinds of stretch in one concept, so it is hard to take away with a single adjustment. The triangle read becomes a whole family in the next chapter, where the routes get deeper and the quarterback has more time.

Spacing: five windows

Every concept so far stretches one or two defenders. **Spacing** stretches the whole underneath coverage. Four or five receivers run to the same depth, about five or six yards, and settle at even intervals across the field. A zone defense usually has four or five underneath defenders; spacing puts a receiver in the seam between each pair of them.

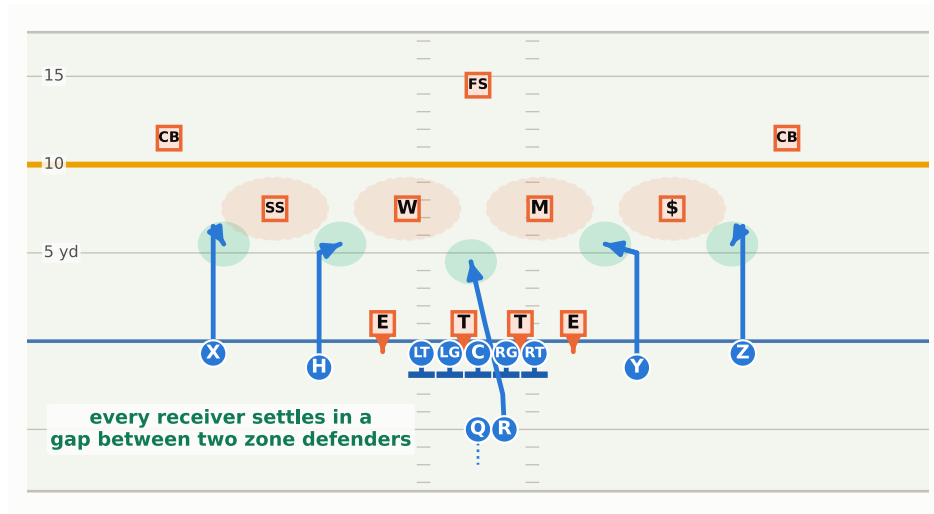


Figure 6: Spacing against a Cover 3 look, drawn at the moment the quarterback's back foot lands: the four underneath zone defenders have finished their drops (their areas shaded orange) and the corners and the deep safety are deep. Five receivers sit at five or six yards, evenly spread: X and Z at the numbers outside the curl-flat defenders, H and Y in the gaps just inside them, and the running back, who checked for a blitz first, over the ball between the two linebackers. Every receiver is in a gap between two defenders (green).

Spacing is the quick game's answer to a defense that plays zone and refuses to rush more than four. There is no single defender to read; instead the quarterback picks a side before the snap (by leverage, or by which side has fewer defenders) and throws to whichever receiver on that side is open when his foot lands. Its weakness is the mirror image: against man coverage there are no gaps to sit in, so the receivers have to beat their men, and the sitting routes turn into breaks away from leverage, the same rule as the stick route.

Spacing is an old idea, and a natural fit for the Air Raid offenses of Hal Mumme and Mike Leach in college football, which spread receivers across the whole width of the field and made the quick game one of their foundations;¹⁰ The College Laboratory tells that story.

Speed out: beating a soft corner to the sideline

Not every quick throw is a two-man read. The **speed out** is a single receiver's route, thrown on timing against one particular look: a cornerback playing well off, with inside leverage, who is backing up at the snap.

¹⁰Ralph D. Russo, "Air Raid evolution: Pioneering offense passes test of time," Associated Press, Aug. 24, 2022, on the offense "birthed from the mind of Hal Mumme" and "inspired by LaVell Edwards' BYU passing game and Bill Walsh's West Coast offense," whose "foundational concepts and plays" it lists as "mesh, Y cross, four verts, the quick game": <https://kvia.com/ap-texas/2022/08/24/air-raid-evolution-pioneering-offense-passes-test-of-time/>

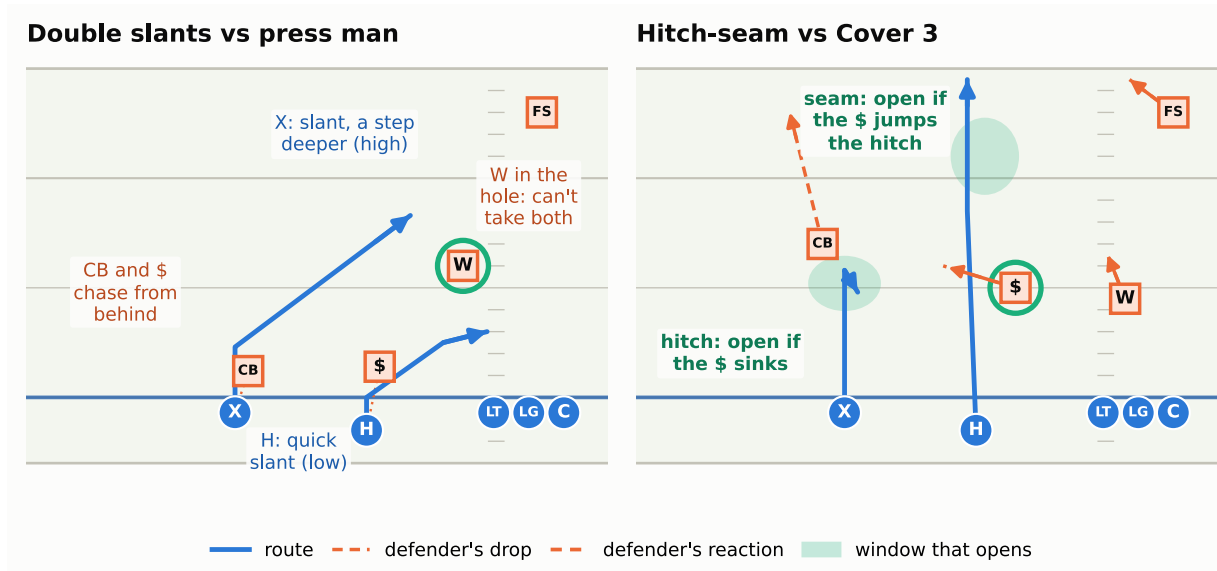


Figure 8: Two quick pairs, both on the offense's left. Left: double slants against press man coverage with one defender, the Will linebacker (W, ringed), sitting in the middle as a helper. H runs a quick, flat slant underneath him; X a deeper slant above him. The defenders covering X and H start on the receivers' outside shoulders and have to chase from behind, and the one helper in the middle can't take both. Right: hitch-seam against a Cover 3 look. X runs a hitch underneath the bailing cornerback, H a seam straight up the field. The ringed flat defender (\$) can stay low on the hitch or carry the seam, not both: if he sinks, throw the hitch; if he jumps the hitch, throw the seam behind him, away from the deep middle safety.

Seven concepts, and notice how few ideas they really contain. Each one picks a defender, puts two receivers on opposite sides of him (above and below, or inside and outside), and asks the quarterback to watch that one man and throw to the one he doesn't take. That is the entire logic of the quick game, which is why a quarterback can run it at full speed with his eyes on a single player.

Beating press: the receiver's side

Everything so far assumed the receivers get into their routes on time. The defense's most direct answer to the quick game is to make sure they don't. In **press** coverage, a cornerback lines up right on the receiver, a yard or so away, and tries to jam him at the snap: punch him, reroute him, knock him off his path. Its opposite, off coverage, is a defender who starts five to ten yards away and gives ground (Coverage Fundamentals covers both from the defender's side).

Press attacks the quick game where it lives: the timing. A slant that should break at three steps breaks at five because the receiver spent two of them fighting through a jam, and the quarterback, whose back foot has already landed, is left holding the ball with a rush closing in. That is why press and the quick game are a matched pair in every game plan: the defense presses to wreck the rhythm, and the offense answers with receivers who can beat press quickly and routes that use the press defender's own position against him.

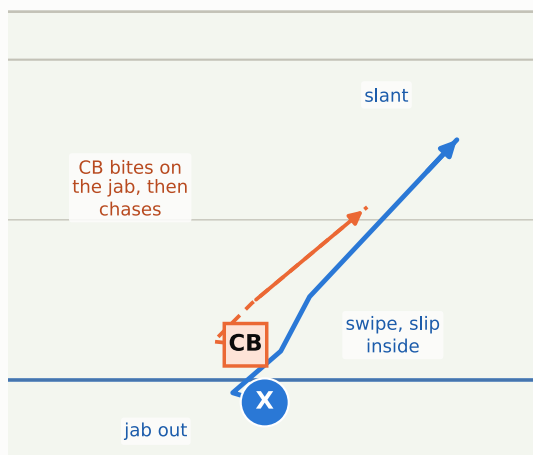
The rules frame the fight. Within five yards of the line of scrimmage, an NFL defender may contact a receiver in front of him; beyond five yards, until the ball is thrown, contact that impedes the receiver is illegal contact or defensive holding.¹¹ So press is a five-yard fight, and the receiver's goal is to get through those five yards on his path and on time. Here is how he does it, from the receiver's side of the ball.

Release: getting off the line

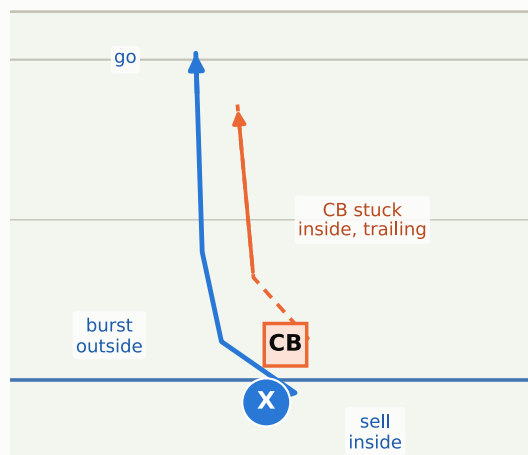
A **release** is a receiver's first moves off the line against a pressing defender: footwork to make the defender commit, and hands to keep the defender's hands off him. The defender wants to get his hands on the receiver's chest and mirror him; the receiver wants to make him move first, then go the other way.

¹¹NFL Rulebook, Rule 8, Section 4 ("Legal and Illegal Contact With Eligible Receivers"), Articles 1–3: within the area five yards beyond the line of scrimmage, a defender may chuck an eligible receiver in front of him; beyond five yards, while the passer is still in the pocket with the ball, he may not initiate contact with a receiver who is trying to evade him (illegal contact: five yards and an automatic first down). Grabbing or restricting a receiver is defensive holding (Rule 12, Section 1): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/> ; NFL Video Rulebook, "Illegal Contact": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/illegal-contact> . After the Patriots' physical coverage in the 2003 season's AFC Championship Game, the Competition Committee made illegal contact and defensive holding a point of emphasis for 2004: NBC Sports Boston, "They called it the 'Ty Law Rule'": <https://www.nbcsportsboston.com/nfl/new-england-patriots/they-called-it-the-ty-law-rule-and-that-was-ok-with-him/393549/>

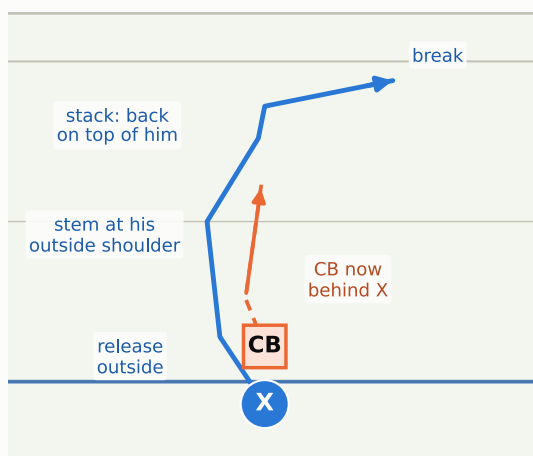
1. Inside release



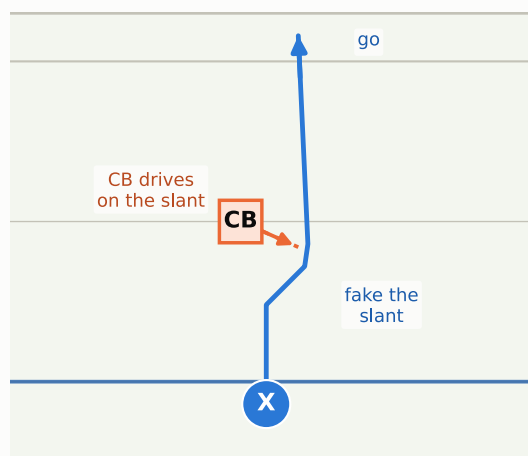
2. Outside release



3. Stem and stack, then break



4. Double move (slant-and-go)



— route - - - defender's reaction

Figure 9: Four ways a receiver (X) beats a cornerback (CB), drawn from above on the offense's left: three against a cornerback pressing him, and one against a cornerback sitting on short routes. Blue is the receiver's path, orange dashes the cornerback's reaction. 1. Inside release: a hard jab step outside makes the cornerback shift his weight that way; the receiver swipes the cornerback's hands down and slips inside, onto a slant. 2. Outside release: he sells inside, then bursts outside and up the sideline, with the cornerback trailing on his inside hip. 3. Stem and stack: after the release, the receiver runs his stem straight at the cornerback's outside shoulder, as if going deep, then moves back directly in front of him (the stack) before breaking. 4. The double move: against a cornerback playing off and waiting for the short route, he fakes a quick slant, the cornerback drives on it, and the receiver turns up the field behind him.

The inside and outside releases are mirror images, and both rest on the same idea: **make the defender declare first**. A pressing cornerback usually aligns with leverage too, a shade inside or outside, and he wants the receiver to run into his strength. A good release attacks one side hard enough that the defender has to move his feet or reach with his hands to stop it, and then goes to the other side. The hands matter as much as the feet: receivers swipe the defender's hands down, chop at his wrists, or rip an arm through under his, all to keep him from getting a firm grip on the chest. A defender who lands a two-hand jam controls the receiver; one who whiffs is beaten and has to turn and chase.

Which release a receiver uses is not his whim. The route decides. A slant *needs* an inside release, a fade or go route an outside one. That's why the pre-snap read includes the press corner's leverage: a corner pressing with inside leverage is daring the receiver to win inside, so the quarterback may prefer the fade or a quick out to that side, and the slant to the other.

Stem and stack: setting up the break

Once he is off the line, the receiver still has to get open at the top of the route. The **stem** is the part of the route between the release and the break, and good receivers treat it as a weapon rather than a run-up. By aiming the stem at one of the defender's shoulders, the receiver tells him what the route "is": run at his outside shoulder at full speed and the defender has to worry about the go route and turn his hips to run, which makes a break inside much harder for him to match.

Against a defender trailing in man coverage, the receiver also wants to **stack** him: get directly in front of him, on his line, so the defender is behind the receiver and can't see or reach the ball without going through him. A stacked defender can't undercut a throw, can't play the receiver's hands, and has to guess which way the break will go. The best route runners win most of their battles here, in the yard or two between "released" and "broken," and that's why coaches say a route is won before the break, not at it.

The break and the catch point

The **break** is the cut itself, and its quality decides how much separation the receiver has when the ball arrives. A sharp break (sink the hips, plant, explode the other way) creates space against a defender who is mirroring. A rounded break keeps speed, as in the speed out, and works against a defender who is backing up. Either way, on a quick throw the ball is usually already in the air.

Then comes the **catch point**: the moment the ball and the receiver's hands meet. If the release, stem and break were good, it's an easy catch with the defender a step or two away. If not, it's a **contested catch**: a catch made with a defender close enough to touch the ball or the receiver's hands. FSN's charters flagged about 14% of 2025 targets as contested; only about 42% of those were caught, against about 71% of the rest.¹² The quick game is designed to avoid contested catches: a well-run slant-flat or stick throws to the receiver who is *not* covered. When a quick throw becomes a contested catch, usually against press-man coverage with no open receiver, the offense is relying on a receiver who can win at the catch point, and on a quarterback willing to throw him the ball anyway. Throws placed where only the receiver can reach them, like the back-shoulder throw, are how good pairs make those catches more likely.

The double move: punishing the defender who guesses right

The quick game creates its own counter. A cornerback who has watched film of an offense throwing slant after slant and hitch after hitch learns to sit on those routes, and to jump them the instant the receiver breaks. That is exactly the defender a **double move** is built for. The receiver fakes a quick route, the quarterback often pumps as if throwing it, and when the defender drives on the fake, the receiver turns up the field behind him. The common forms are named for their two parts: slant-and-go (the sluggo), out-and-up, hitch-and-go, and the stutter-go, a fake stop.

The double move is the quick game's insurance policy. Without it, a defense could squeeze the short routes harder every week. With it, every corner who jumps a slant risks a long touchdown. The cost is time: a double move takes three seconds or more to develop, so it needs protection the quick game itself never asks for, which is why offenses tend to call it with an extra blocker, after they have thrown the short version often enough to bait the defender.

Quick screens: now and bubble

The quick game has two close cousins that aren't really passes in the usual sense. Both are screens, throws to a receiver behind or at the line of scrimmage with teammates blocking in front of him, and both are thrown the instant the ball is snapped. (Slower screens to running backs and tight ends, with linemen releasing to block, are in Play-Action, Bootlegs, and Screens.)

A **now screen** goes to an outside receiver. He takes a step back (or none) and catches the ball a second after the snap, while the receiver inside him blocks the nearest defender. Teams call versions of it a smoke screen or a quick screen; the names vary by playbook (some use "smoke" for the version with no blocker at all), but the idea is the same.

¹²Course calculation from FSN charting ([is_contested_ball](#)) joined to nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season: 16,733 pass attempts excluding throwaways and spikes; 13.9% charted as contested. Completion rate 41.9% on contested throws, 71.1% on the rest. Contested throws went farther (12.7 yards in the air on average, against 7.1), which accounts for part of the gap.

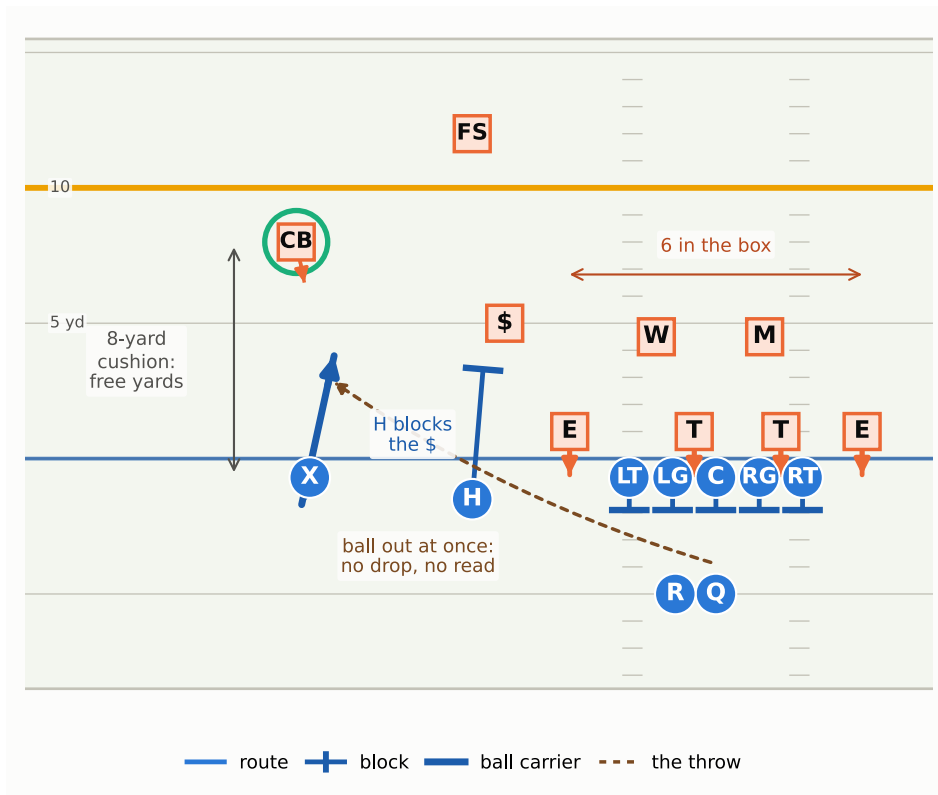


Figure 10: A now screen against off coverage, the offense's left side. The corner back lines up eight yards off X, so X catches the ball about a second after the snap and is already running before the corner back can close. H blocks the slot defender (\$), the only other defender nearby. The box holds six defenders, so outside it on this side the defense has just the corner back and the \$ underneath, with a safety twelve yards deep. The quarterback can decide this before the snap from the cushion alone.

The now screen exists to punish one thing: **a defender playing far off the ball**. An eight-yard cushion is eight yards the defender has to cover before he can make a tackle, and a receiver who catches the ball at the snap gets to spend those yards running instead. Many offenses tag the now screen onto ordinary plays, so that the quarterback, seeing the corner back backed up eight yards, can throw it as a free five yards instead of running the called play.

The **bubble screen** is the inside version. A slot receiver drifts a step or two back and then out toward the sideline, a path that looks like a bubble when you draw it, and catches the ball already running, while the receivers outside him turn and block.

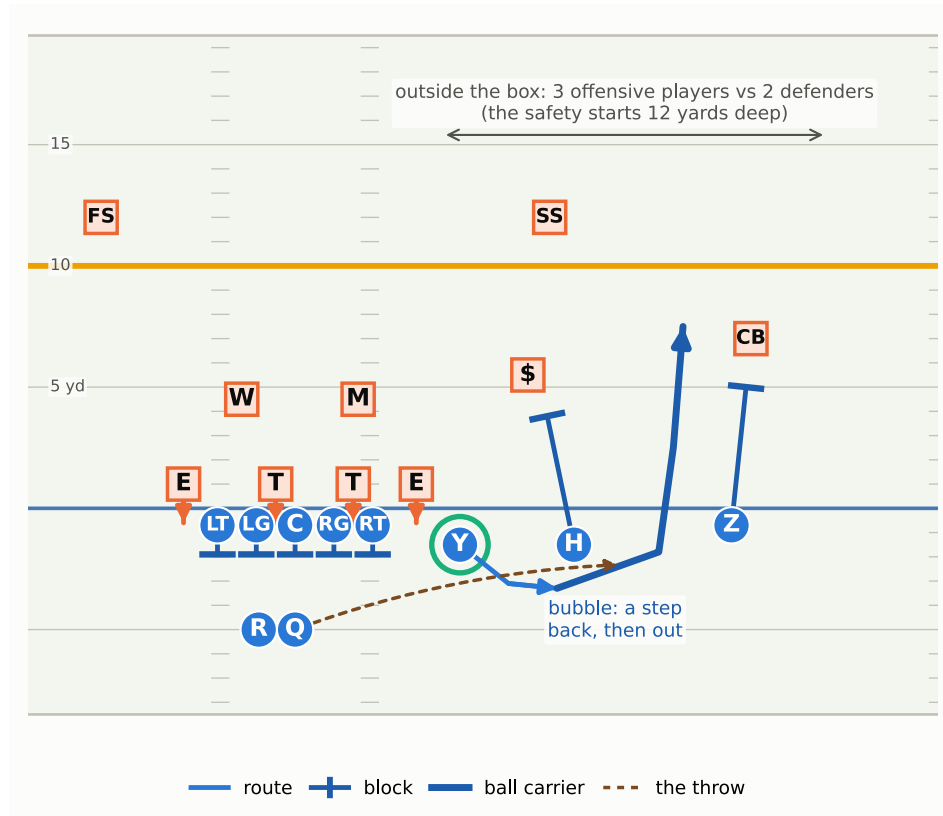


Figure 11: A bubble screen to the trips side, on the offense's right. Y, the innermost of three receivers, bows back and out and catches the ball on the run, already moving toward the sideline. Z blocks the cornerback and H blocks the slot defender (\$). Outside the box on that side the offense has three players (two blockers and the ball carrier) against two defenders; the third, the safety (SS), starts twelve yards deep. Before the snap, the quarterback counted those numbers.

Coaches who throw these screens on almost every snap, as many college offenses do and some NFL offenses do, often teach the decision with three words: **numbers, leverage, grass**.

- **Numbers:** count the defenders outside the box on one side and compare them with the offense's players there. Three against two is a screen. This is the box count seen from the other side: every defender a defense puts in the box to stop the run is one fewer outside it.
- **Leverage:** can the blockers get between their defenders and the ball carrier? A defender lined up inside, near the ball, is easy to block from the outside; one lined up wide is not.
- **Grass:** how much space is there between the ball carrier and the nearest unblocked defender? A safety twelve yards deep is twelve yards of grass.

That is why quick screens are often thought of as part of the run game, and why they are so often packaged with runs. If the defense puts a seventh or eighth man in the box to stop the run, someone outside the box has left, and the screen to that side gets better. When the quarterback decides between the run and the screen *after* the snap, by reading a defender, the play becomes a run-pass option, and the bubble attached to a run is one of the most common RPOs in football (bubble RPO).

One rule detail makes the bubble unusual. Because it is often thrown sideways or slightly backward, a bubble that is thrown behind the receiver is a backward pass, and a backward pass that hits the ground is a live ball, not an incompleteness: either team can recover it.¹³ That's why you sometimes see a defender scoop up a dropped bubble and run the other way, and why offenses want the throw to be clearly forward or clearly caught.

¹³NFL Rulebook, Rule 8, Section 7 ("Backward Pass and Fumble"): players of either team may catch a backward pass, or recover one after it touches the ground, and advance it; the special fourth-down and final-two-minutes limits on advancing apply to fumbles, not backward passes: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/> ; NFL Video Rulebook, "Backward Pass": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/backward-pass>

The answer to press and blitz

Now put the chapter together. The two most aggressive things a defense can do against the pass are to **blitz** (send more rushers than the offense can comfortably block) and to **press** (jam receivers to destroy the timing). Both are bets that the quarterback won't get the ball out in time. The quick game is the offense taking that bet.

The arithmetic of a blitz explains why. A five-man pressure sends five rushers, leaving six defenders to cover. If the offense keeps five or six men in to block, that is still enough to pick up everyone, but if it sends five receivers out, one rusher may come free, and the quarterback has to throw before he arrives. Pass protection calls that a hot route or a sight adjustment: a throw, often a quick one, aimed at the area the blitzzer just left. Meanwhile, the defenders who are left behind are usually playing man coverage, often pressed, with little help. A quick throw attacks every part of that: it beats the free rusher to the quarterback, and it attacks defenders who are alone in coverage with no one underneath to help.

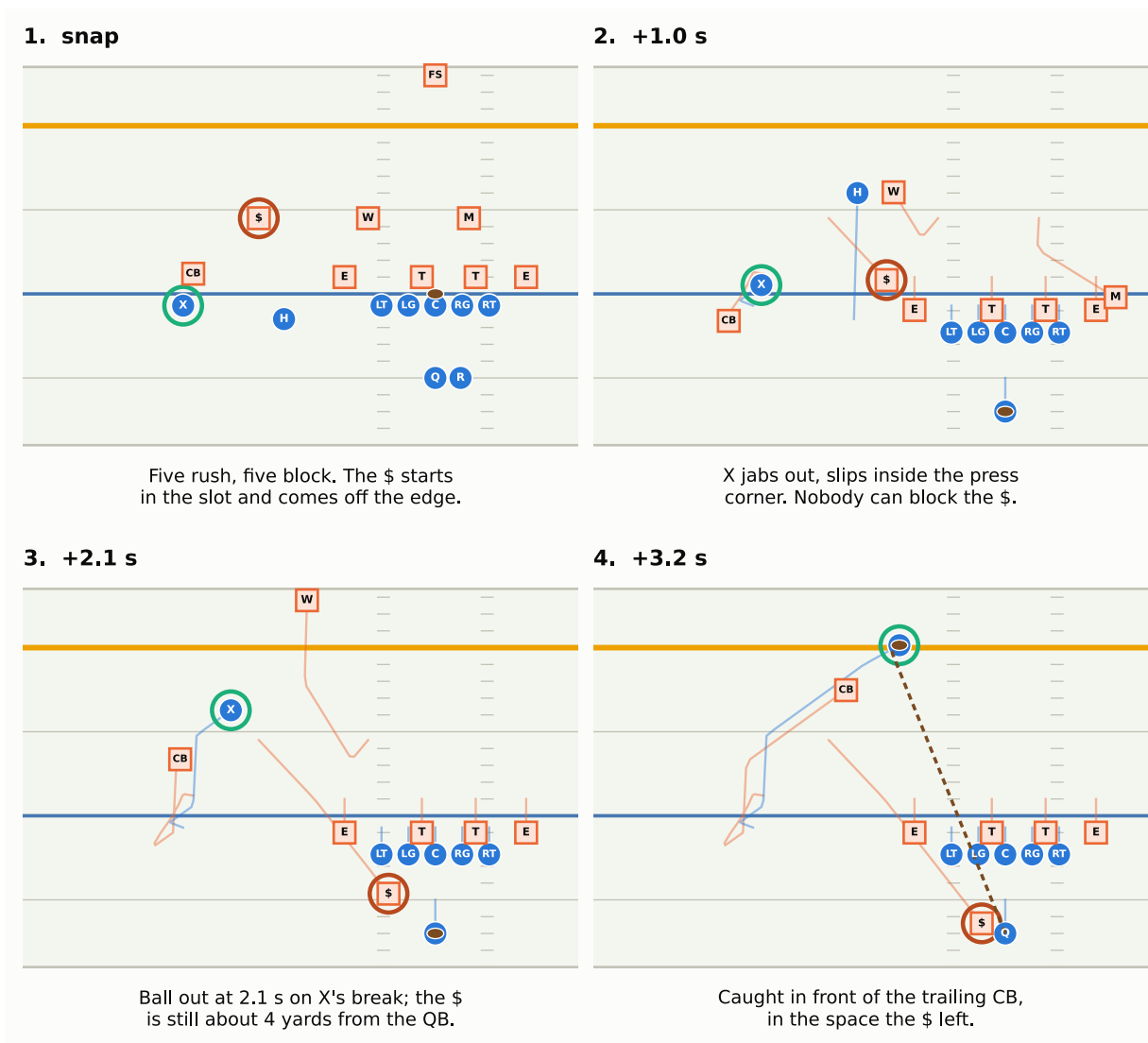


Figure 12: Quick game against a five-man pressure (simulated, BDB-format tracking). The defense shows press-man coverage with one deep safety (Cover 1) and blitzes the slot defender (\$, ringed in orange) off the offense's left edge. The running back has released into a route, so five blockers face five rushers, and the blitzzer from the edge is too far outside for the left tackle to reach in time. X (ringed in green) beats the press cornerback with an inside release and breaks in on a slant, into the area the blitzzer left. The ball is out 2.1 seconds after the snap, a beat before the blitzzer gets there.

Two details in that play are worth slowing down for. First, the quarterback knew before the snap where the ball was likely to go. Pressed corners with a single safety deep is a classic pressure look, and the slot defender creeping toward the line told him which area might empty. His pre-snap read was "if the \$ comes, the ball goes to X, inside, right now." Second, the slant was the right route for the press cornerback's leverage: he lined up on X's outside, so an inside release was the release X could win.

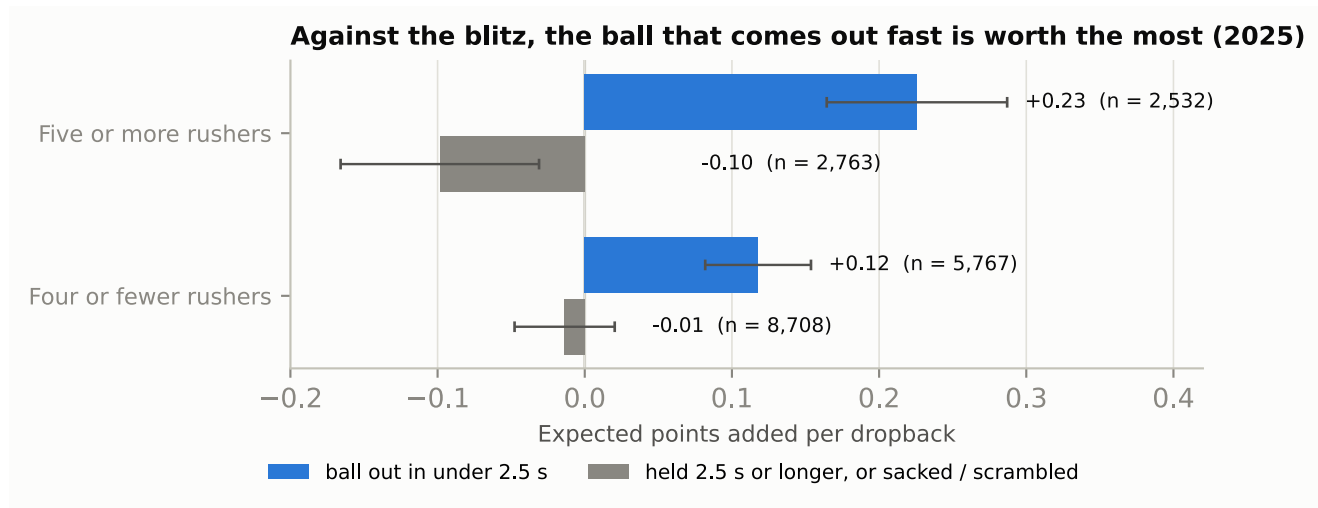


Figure 13: What the quick game is worth against the blitz. Every 2025 regular-season dropback with a charted number of pass rushers, sorted by the rush (four or fewer, or five or more) and by the outcome: a pass out in under 2.5 seconds (blue), or anything slower, sacks and scrambles included (grey). The bars are expected points added (EPA) per dropback; the thin lines are 95% confidence intervals. Against five or more rushers, quick throws gained about a third of a point more per dropback than everything else. A caution on reading it: quarterbacks hold the ball longer partly *because* nobody is open, so this comparison flatters quick throws; it shows the size of the stakes, not a controlled experiment.

The chart puts a number on the trade.¹⁴ Against a standard four-man rush, a quick throw was worth about an eighth of a point more than a slower outcome. Against five or more rushers, the gap roughly doubles: quick throws gained about +0.23 expected points per dropback, while everything slower, with the sacks that a blitz produces, averaged about -0.10. A blitz is a coin flip the defense is offering. A quarterback who gets the ball out before the extra rusher arrives wins the flip far more often than he loses it, which is why blitz-happy defenses spend so much effort disguising when and where the pressure will come from (Zone Blitz and Simulated Pressure).

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game, the blitz is a button you press to make the other player panic. In the NFL, a quarterback who sees six defenders at the line is usually not panicking; his offense has spent the week on what to do when that happens. Every quick concept has a “hot” version, the protection call tells the quarterback which rusher, if any, will be unblocked, and the receivers know which routes become sight adjustments. The real contest is whether the defense can *hide* the blitz until it’s too late to adjust, or show one and not bring it. That’s why the pre-snap dance of defenders walking up and backing out, covered in The Pre-Snap Phase, matters so much.

Film room: three offenses that lived on it

The quick game is in every playbook, but a few offenses built their identity on it. Each of the three below shows a different reason to.

¹⁴Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play and participation data (`number_of_pass_rushers`, `time_to_throw`), 2025 regular season dropbacks with a charted rush count. “Quick” = a pass attempt out in under 2.5 seconds; “held” = an attempt out in 2.5 seconds or more, a sack, or a scramble. EPA per dropback: four or fewer rushers, quick +0.118 (n = 5,767) and held -0.014 (n = 8,708); five or more rushers, quick +0.226 (n = 2,532) and held -0.098 (n = 2,763). Five or more rushed on 27% of these dropbacks.

i Film room: New Orleans Saints 2017–2019

The quick game as accuracy. Sean Payton (head coach 2006–2021) and Drew Brees (quarterback 2006–2020) ran one of the most varied offenses of their era, but its engine late in Brees’s career was the short, on-time throw. Brees broke the NFL’s single-season completion-percentage record in 2017 (72.0%) and broke it again in 2018 (74.4%).¹⁵ In 2019, among quarterbacks with 300 or more attempts, he had the second-fastest average time to throw in the league and one of the shortest average throws (about 6.5 yards past the line of scrimmage), and his top receiver, Michael Thomas, set the single-season receptions record with 149, about seven in ten of them on throws that traveled less than ten yards in the air.¹⁶

What to notice on the tape: the ball leaving on Brees’s last step, again and again, and Thomas winning at the top of the route with his size: getting inside the cornerback on the slant, then shielding the ball with his body at the catch point. The Saints threw short not because they couldn’t throw deep, but because a 74% completion rate with yards after the catch was, play after play, worth more.

i Film room: New England Patriots 2007–2012

The quick game as an option tree. The Tom Brady–era Patriots ran the quick game through a small, quick slot receiver. Wes Welker caught 112 passes in 2007, his first season in New England, and 123 in 2009 and 122 in 2011, leading the league in catches three times in five years.¹⁷ Most of those catches came within a few yards of the line of scrimmage, many on option routes from the slot in which Welker read his defender’s leverage and broke away from it, the same rule the stick route uses. Brady’s internal clock stayed fast long after: in his final season, 2022 with Tampa Bay, at 45, he had the fastest average time to throw of any regular starter.¹⁸

What to notice on the tape: Welker lined up inside, a defender over him trying to guess his break, and Brady throwing as Welker turned his head, before the break had even finished. That is a pre-snap read and a rhythm throw working together, with a receiver and quarterback who had run the same routes against the same leverages thousands of times.

¹⁵Pro Football Reference, Drew Brees career passing (2017: 386 of 536, 72.0%; 2018: 364 of 489, 74.4%), and the NFL record book (single-season completion percentage): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/B/BreeDr00.htm> . Guinness World Records lists 74.4% as the record (and 72.0% in 2017 as the mark it broke): <https://www.guinnessworldrecords.com/world-records/93395-highest-completion-percentage-nfl-season> . In nflverse play-by-play no qualified passer from 2019 through 2025 topped 74.4% (the closest was Brees himself, about 74% in 2019). Payton was the Saints’ head coach from 2006 to 2021 but was suspended for the 2012 season.

¹⁶NFL.com, “Saints’ Michael Thomas sets NFL reception record” (Dec. 22, 2019), his 144th catch passing Marvin Harrison’s 143 (2002): <https://www.nfl.com/news/saints-michael-thomas-sets-nfl-reception-record-0ap3000001090697> ; he finished with 149 (NFL.com, “Saints WR Michael Thomas named 2019 NFL OPOY”: <https://www.nfl.com/news/saints-wr-michael-thomas-named-2019-nfl-opoy-0ap3000001100165>). Course calculations from nflverse play-by-play and participation (NGS-sourced) data: 104 of Thomas’s 149 catches (70%) came on throws of less than 10 air yards, and half within 5; Brees’s 2019 time to throw averaged 2.57 s, second-fastest of 26 passers with 300+ attempts, with an average depth of target of about 6.5 yards.

¹⁷Pro Football Reference, Wes Welker career receiving: 112 receptions (2007, tied for the NFL lead), 123 (2009, NFL lead), 122 (2011, NFL lead): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/W/WelkWe00.htm> . The 2007 lead was shared with Cincinnati’s T. J. Houshmandzadeh (also 112). In nflverse play-by-play, his targets in 2009–2012 averaged about 5.5 to 7.7 yards in the air, against a league average of about 8.2 to 8.7, and in 2007, 2009 and 2011 between 51% and 65% of his catches came on throws of 5 air yards or less.

¹⁸Course calculation from nflverse participation data (`time_to_throw`, NGS-sourced), 2022 regular season, passers with 300 or more attempts: Brady averaged 2.45 seconds, fastest of 29. He was second-fastest in 2021.

The quick game as an adaptation. In 2018, Patrick Mahomes’s first season as the starter, the Chiefs threw deep more than almost anyone, with Tyreek Hill as the threat. Hill was traded to Miami in March 2022.¹⁹ Over the next three seasons, Andy Reid’s offense rebuilt itself around shorter throws to Travis Kelce and a rotating cast of receivers, and defenses that played two deep safeties to take away the big play invited exactly that. The figure below shows how far the change went: by 2023 and 2024 the Chiefs’ average throw was the second-shortest in the league. They won the Super Bowl after the 2022 and 2023 seasons anyway.

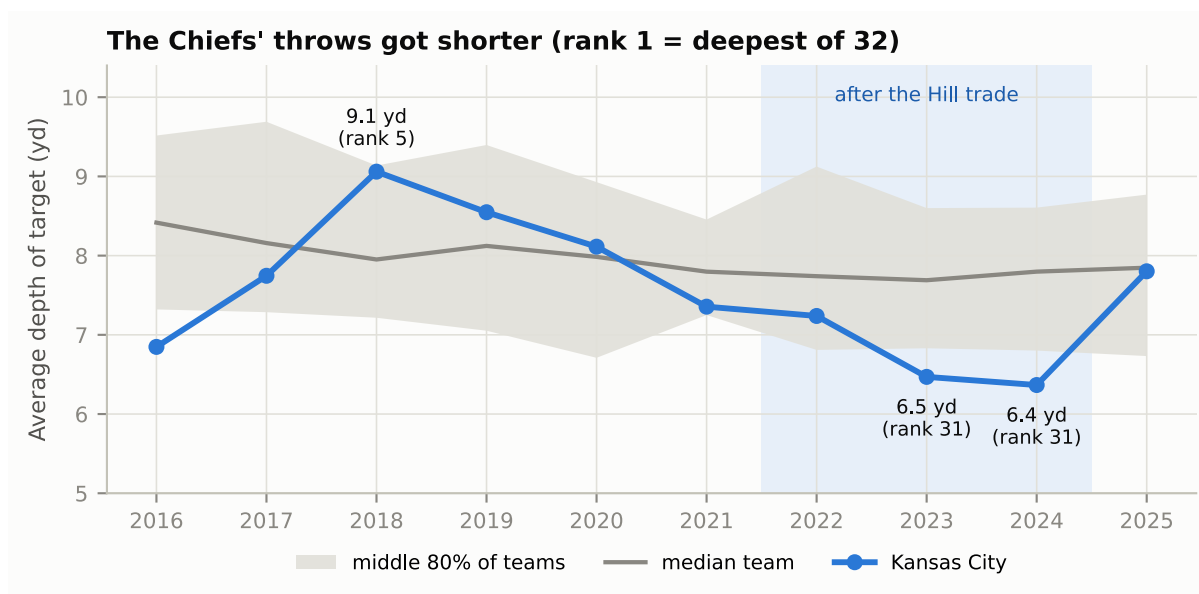


Figure 14: The Chiefs’ average depth of target (how far past the line of scrimmage the ball was thrown, on average) by season, 2016–2025, against the league: the grey band holds the middle 80% of teams and the grey line is the median team. Kansas City went from one of the deepest-throwing teams in 2018 (fifth of 32) to second-shallowest in 2023 and 2024, the seasons after Tyreek Hill’s trade, with Travis Kelce at the center of the short game. Regular season, sacks and spikes excluded; nflverse play-by-play.

What to notice on the tape: Kelce, lined up in the slot or as the innermost receiver of trips, running a stick or an option route at five to eight yards and settling in the space between two zone defenders, with Mahomes throwing as he turns. Nearly three of every four of Kelce’s targets in 2022 traveled less than ten yards in the air.²⁰ The quick game here is not a failure to throw deep. It is a great offense taking what a defense built to stop the deep ball leaves underneath, play after play, and trusting its receivers to make yards after the catch.

¹⁹NFL.com, “Chiefs trading WR Tyreek Hill to Dolphins for multiple draft picks, including 2022 first-rounder” (March 23, 2022): five picks, the 2022 first-, second- and fourth-rounders and 2023 fourth- and sixth-rounders: <https://www.nfl.com/news/chiefs-trading-wr-tyreek-hill-to-dolphins-for-multiple-draft-picks>

²⁰Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular season: Kansas City’s average depth of target was 9.06 yards in 2018 (5th deepest of 32), 7.24 in 2022 (23rd), 6.47 in 2023 and 6.37 in 2024 (31st both years), and 7.80 in 2025 (17th). Travis Kelce drew 153 targets in 2022, 72.5% of them under 10 air yards.

Watch for it on Sunday

💡 Watch for it: one-two-throw

Before the snap

- **The corners.** Off or pressed? Inside or outside the receiver? A corner seven yards off with outside leverage is inviting a slant or a now screen; a pressed corner is daring the receiver to beat him off the line.
- **The slot defender.** Where is the man between the slot receiver and the box? He is the read on almost every quick concept to that side. If he walks up toward the line, think blitz, and think quick throw.
- **Count outside the box.** Three receivers against two defenders on one side, with the safety far away, is a screen waiting to happen.

At the snap: the stopwatch. Count “one-thousand-one, one-thousand-two” from the snap. If the ball is gone before you finish “two,” you just watched the quick game. Count a dozen dropbacks in a game and you’ll find that roughly half of them are out before “two-and-a-half.”

After the throw

- On the replay, find the one defender between the two receivers on the side the ball went. Did he widen, sink or sit? The ball went to the receiver he didn’t take.
- When the defense blitzes, watch where the ball goes. Usually it goes quickly to the area the blitzer came from.

For your prediction log (How to Watch a Broadcast): before each third-and-short-to-medium, write *quick* or *not quick*, and the side you expect, based on the corners’ leverage. Then time the throw.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: pick a side

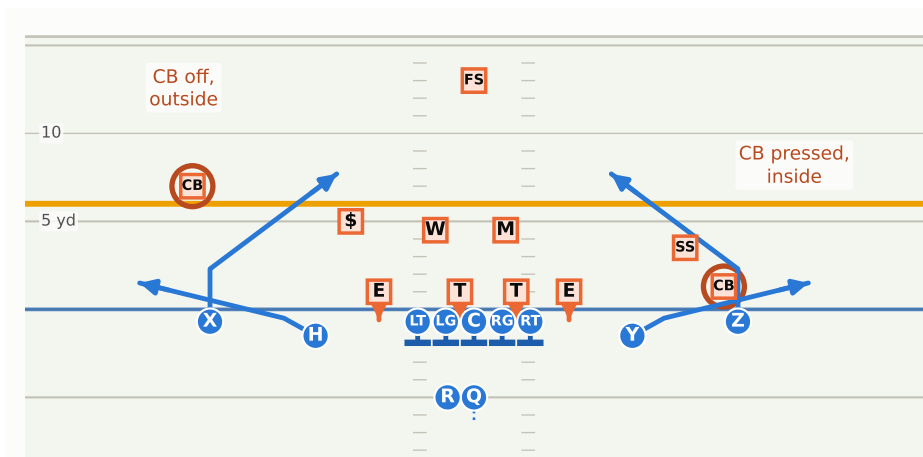


Figure 15: Second-and-6. The offense has called slant-flat to both sides and left the choice of side to the quarterback. Left: the cornerback is seven yards off X with outside leverage, and the slot defender (\$) is inside H. Right: the cornerback is pressed on Z with inside leverage, and the safety (SS) has walked out wide, outside Y, almost in the flat already.

Which side should the quarterback pick, and which defender does he watch after the snap?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: six at the line

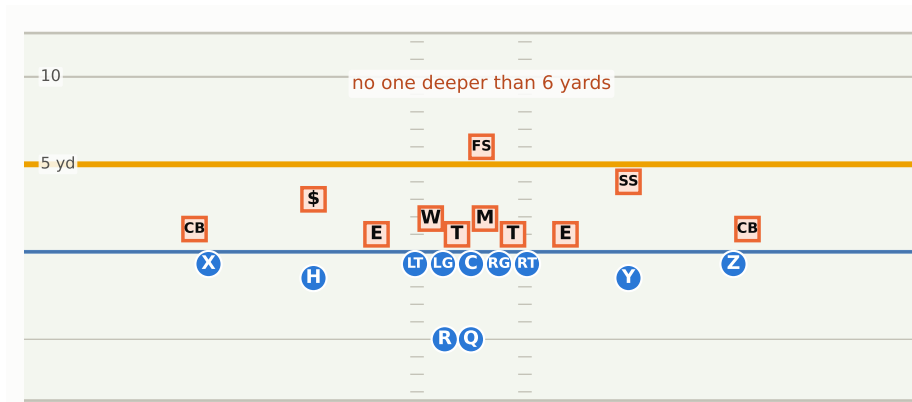


Figure 16: Third-and-5. The defense walks both safeties down and shows six defenders on or near the line, with both cornerbacks pressed and nobody deeper than about six yards. The offense has five linemen and a running back to block.

Count the threat. What kind of throw does the offense want, how fast, and to whom?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: count them

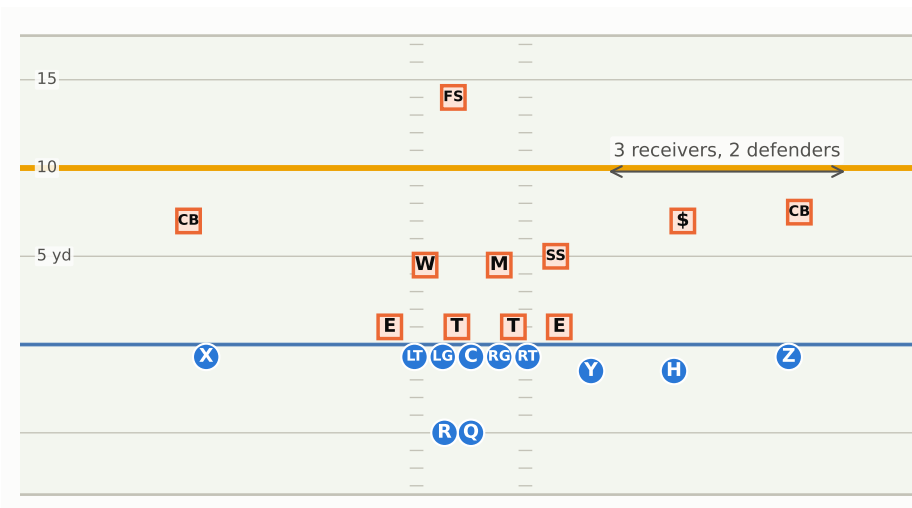


Figure 17: First-and-10. The offense lines up in trips to its right. The defense has seven defenders in or near the box, with a safety walked down beside the linebackers. On the trips side only the cornerback and the slot defender (\$) are outside the box, both about seven yards off, and the other safety is fourteen yards deep in the middle.

The defense has loaded the box to stop the run. What quick throw does that invite, and why?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- The **quick game** is the passing game's fast lane: a short drop, short routes and a rhythm throw, out in about **2.5 seconds or less**. It is roughly half of what NFL offenses throw.
- It exists for **three jobs**: beat the rush with the clock, keep the offense **on schedule** with high-percentage throws, and **stretch the run game sideways** by getting the ball to fast players in space. It trades depth for certainty and needs yards after the catch and a deep threat to keep the bargain.

- Every quick concept puts **two receivers on opposite sides of one defender**, high and low (slant-flat, hitch-seam, double slants) or inside and outside (stick, spacing), or both (snag's triangle), and the quarterback throws to the one that defender doesn't take.
- Most of the decision is made **before the snap**: read the defender's **leverage**, cushion and help, and throw away from leverage.
- **Press** is the defense's answer to the quick game's timing; the receiver's answer is the **release, stem, stack and break**, and the **double move** punishes a defender who jumps the short route.
- **Now and bubble screens** punish soft and outnumbered alignments (numbers, leverage, grass), and against **the blitz**, the ball that comes out fast is worth the most.

Connections

Builds on: Passing Fundamentals (the routes, drops and stretches every concept here is made of) and Pass Protection (hot routes, sight adjustments and the five-, six- and seven-man protections the quick game leans on), with the defensive basics of A First Look at Defense.

Sets up: Dropback Concepts takes the same stretches deeper, with more time and longer progressions; Run-Pass Options attaches the quick throws and screens to runs; Quarterback Play covers anticipation, footwork and the numbers for judging accuracy. On the defensive side, Coverage Fundamentals teaches press and off coverage from the cornerback's side, and Blitz and Man Pressure does the blitz math from the defense's. Concepts Versus Coverages finally pairs each concept with the coverages it beats, and Third Down shows where the quick game earns its keep.

Case studies: Walsh's 49ers and the West Coast offense and Andy Reid's Chiefs.

Go deeper

- Bill Walsh, with Brian Billick and James A. Peterson, *Finding the Winning Edge* (1997): the coach's own account of how he built a passing game around timing and short throws.
- Chris B. Brown, *The Art of Smart Football* (2015) and *The Essential Smart Football* (2012), and his Smart Football site: clear essays on stick, snag, spacing and why they work.
- Tim Layden, *Blood, Sweat and Chalk* (2010): the chapter on Walsh traces the West Coast offense back to the Cincinnati years.
- **From diagrams to real tracking data.** The two animations above are gridiron simulations in NFL Big Data Bowl coordinates. The 2025 Big Data Bowl release (2022 season, weeks 1–9) records every player ten times a second, and its play and player files include each play's time to throw and each receiver's charted route, so you can find real quick throws and watch them. The data needs a free Kaggle login, so this code is not run when the book is built.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

The left side, reading the slot defender (\$). Run through the pre-snap read on each side.

On the **right**, both routes are in trouble before the snap. The cornerback is pressed with inside leverage, sitting right where Z's slant wants to go, so Z has to beat a jam *and* get across the cornerback's face; and the safety has already widened to the flat, standing where Y's flat route ends. One defender is in each receiver's path.

On the **left**, the cornerback is seven yards off and outside X, which concedes the slant (away from leverage), and the slot defender is inside H, the one man who has to choose between the two routes. That's the slant-flat picture from earlier in the chapter. After the snap the quarterback watches only the \$: if he widens with H, throw the slant; if he sits, throw the flat.

This is why offenses call a quick concept to both sides. The defense has to give something away somewhere, and the quarterback's pre-snap job is to find where.

Answer 2.

A quick throw, out in well under two seconds, most likely a slant to whichever outside receiver the press corner's leverage lets go inside. This is a "zero" look: no deep safety at all (Cover 0). If all of them come, the defense rushes as many as eight: four linemen, two linebackers and two defensive backs. The offense has six blockers at most, so at least one rusher, and maybe two, will be unblocked, and nobody can hold the ball. That is the Cover 0 blitz bet: the defense is wagering that the ball can't come out in time.

The offense's answer is the quick game, called before the snap or reached by a hot route. Both corners are pressed and lined up on their receivers' outside shoulders, so the inside release and the slant are the natural throw; with no safety behind them, a slant caught in stride can go a long way. A now screen is a poor choice here: the cornerback is standing a yard away, so there is no cushion to run into.

The defense might be bluffing, of course: show six, bring four, drop two into the throwing lanes. That is exactly why the throw is a *read* of where the extra defenders went, not just a reflex (Zone Blitz and Simulated Pressure).

Answer 3.

A quick screen to the trips side: a bubble to Y, or a now screen to Z. Run the three questions:

- **Numbers:** on the right, outside the box, the offense has three players and the defense two. The safety who would usually be the third defender out there is standing beside the linebackers, in the box. That's the trade the defense made: an extra run defender inside, one fewer pass defender outside.
- **Leverage:** the cornerback and the \$ are both off and roughly over their receivers, so Z and H can get their bodies between them and the ball carrier.
- **Grass:** both are about seven yards off, and the nearest help, the deep safety, is fourteen yards away in the middle of the field. A bubble caught at the snap is five yards gained before anyone can touch it.

A run into the middle would face seven defenders with five linemen to block them (six if a receiver comes in to help): the defense has the numbers inside. The quick screen is how the offense "runs" outside the box instead, and it's why so many offenses attach a bubble to their running plays (Run-Pass Options).